

Gaming on Linux

The State of Affairs



How does the gaming hemisphere fare when it comes to the open source world? Read on to find out!

All of us have played games on the computer at some time or the other. In fact, estimates claim that the gaming industry sells games worth more than \$25 billion per year! Obviously, gaming is a considerable segment of the technology market. As users of Linux, most of us are generally left bereft when it comes to games—many major game-makers release games only for Windows platforms, and those who do consider Linux tend to keep their offerings closed-source or proprietary. However, in spite of such commercially viable (though non-FOSS friendly) policies of game manufacturers, Linux still has its own share of wonderful games, with the likes of Battle for Wesnoth topping the list.

Overview

To begin with, let us be honest. Linux in gaming is still in its infancy, and though the pace of new game development is commendable, the options that you have are just not at par with their proprietary counterparts. Again, this can be attributed to the fact that FOSS has a reputation (which is rather incorrect) among game makers for being commercially unviable, and thus, there are not many developers who create games for Linux. Yet, in the past one year, there has been a change and game manufacturers are taking an interest in Linux too. This shift in thought is partly due to the fact that the ports of

major Windows games to Linux have enjoyed tremendous success, and partly because video drivers for Linux are now more easily available.

Games are almost always classified on the basis of their genre, such as strategy, arcade, campaign, etc. However, tastes differ and while I prefer strategy games, you may not, and vice versa. Thus, in this article, let's look at the FOSS gaming diaspora on the basis of development/deployment. Broadly speaking, the gaming options currently available for FOSS users can be clubbed into three sections.

Games developed natively for Linux

As with any other platform, gaming on Linux, too, thrives mainly on the basis of the games that are built to run natively on Linux. Such native games tend to be totally 'free', though a few of them may be ad-supported. We did a story about major Linux games in the December 2010 issue of LFY (www.linuxforu.com/2010/12/the-games-geeks-play/). However, times have changed since then, and there have been several new releases in the latter part of 2011.

Some of the big names include:

- **Kelgar Alpha:** A first-person RPG (role-playing game).
- **The Legend of Edgar:** A 2D platform game.
- **Tome of Mephistopheles Alpha:** Name sounds good, right? It is a dungeon-based FPS (first person shooter) RPG.